On the Thousandth Night

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The Bonfire Party

CH20603-01

New Age Market

Edgardo the Masseur: ♪"Oh-oh, who could say no to a night like this?"♪

A sound like the bellowing of a yak emerges from behind the flickering campfire.

A circle forms around the flames. Cooper the Healer and Maich the Peddler nestle into some cushions. They exchange a knowing glance.

Cooper the Healer: Careful, Maich, Edgardo's gonna crush your crate if he sits on it—and he'll take Mercuria down with him when he falls.

Maich furrows her brow with a smile and nudges Cooper's shoulder, urging her to pay attention to Edgardo.

Edgardo the Masseur: A warm welcome to you all!

Edgardo the Masseur: Thanks for taking time out from your busy schedules of foreseeing fates, communing with ghosts, and chatting with imaginary friends to join our bonfire bash.

Edgardo the Masseur: I believe everyone knows what happened here.

Edgardo scans the group gathered around the fire. Everyone has settled in their usual spots.

The conspicuous emptiness of certain seats is a stark reminder of their absence.

Edgardo the Masseur: Maich, Cooper, I'm so glad you're still with us.

Maich stands up with a nod, while Cooper blushes behind her swaying skirt.

Edgardo the Masseur: It's been nearly a month since our last get-together, thanks to those tar-bleeding thugs! Oh, their bodies ... They don't deserve my words.

Edgardo waves his hand, as though to banish the discomfort from his thoughts.

Edgardo the Masseur: Because of them, we've lost many dear friends.

Some gaze wistfully into the distance, only to lower their eyes in regret before refocusing on Edgardo.

Edgardo the Masseur: Not only that, but they tried to turn us into their zombies. I can't thank our dear Mercuria and J enough for helping us dodge that bullet. It's thanks to them that we can even be here around the bonfire again.

Edgardo starts to pluck at the guitar in his hands, gently playing a series of monotonous yet poignant tones.

Edgardo the Masseur: To part with friends is to fracture the soul, but life rolls on, and the New Age Market will continue to welcome new faces—its freedom and acceptance will never change.

Edgardo the Masseur: Let us make this gathering a song for a brighter tomorrow—and pay our highest respects to Mercuria and J!

The group's eyes shift to Mercuria. Edgardo's bulky frame makes her look even more petite.

She is swarmed with applause, and a few calls for a speech.

Mercuria: No, there's no need.

Her composed and delicate voice fails to dampen the fervor of the crowd, as the applause and acclamation persist.

Edgardo segues the music into its second phase.

Edgardo the Masseur: We also extend our appreciation to Mr. Legers.

Edgardo the Masseur: He's graciously taken over J's role now that he's off with the Foundation, keeping us safe back in San Fran. He's a big supporter of the market, too.

Eyes scout around for Legers as the clapping and cheering wind down.

Cooper the Healer: Ah, the big guy couldn't make it tonight, huh?

Edgardo the Masseur: That's right, sweetie. Mr. Legers is swamped, busy getting cozy with J's turf to make sure he can keep us safe.

Edgardo the Masseur: He did ask me to send his best, though. Says he hopes tonight's a blast!

The group's inner gloom seems to lift as they catch each other's eyes, affirmed by each other's presence.

But this serene interlude is fleeting.

???: Oops! Sorry!

A timid voice comes from behind them.

???: Excuse me, coming through! Oh, sorry!

Phoebe the Herbalist: Oh!

Dexter the Unlucky One, juggling two buckets of drink, stumbles into view.

Perhaps the load is overwhelming or is obscuring his footing.

As he walks, liquid spills over the sides, like he's some kind of farmer attempting to evenly water his field.

Dexter the Unlucky One: I'm so, so, so sorry. I'm sorry!

Mercuria: Under your right foot.

Mercuria reaches out as she tries to give him a hand.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh!

Despite her warning, Dexter's right foot lands squarely on a crystal ball.

Before they know it, he's lying on his back, and both buckets have emptied their contents over the now-smoldering campfire.

The people's ease is extinguished as quickly as the fire.

Cooper the Healer: Hah!

Edgardo the Masseur: It's out? That wasn't booze you brought back?

Maich the Peddler: You unlucky duck ...

The people's concern quickly shifts from Dexter to the campfire. They peer at the blackened wood.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh ... I ... must've grabbed the wrong ... Maybe it's someone else's ...

Dexter lies there, dazed, covered in a mix of drink and dirt.

Edgardo the Masseur: Get up, you poor kid.

Edgardo puts down his guitar and guides Dexter over to a crate.

Cooper and Maich get up to look for dry wood.

And those who were doused in the drink return to their stalls to get changed.

Everyone moves so adeptly that it's clear they've done this many times.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Can't we have him do something else?

Phoebe's voice emanates from her tent.

Maich the Peddler: You forget? Last time he set the fire, he nearly burned the whole market down.

Maich responds loudly.

Edgardo the Masseur: And remember the time before that, when he sent those invites to the "Society of Supreme Rationality"? They got out compasses, of all things, to hunt for spirits!

Edgardo the Masseur: "Energy fields, lodestones ... Those are all just smoke and mirrors—totally unscientific."

Edgardo mimics their derisive tone.

In the silence that follows, Dexter can hear the hums and sighs of the people.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh, I'm really sorry.

He thumps his forehead with his palm.

Dexter the Unlucky One: I swear, I was paying like 120,000% attention. Mercuria, maybe you could do another purification ritual for me?

Mercuria, still sitting, has already prepared the white sage. The smoke spirals lazily in the air, veiling her gaze.

Mercuria: Please. Come.

Dexter leans over in front of Mercuria. She circles the sage around his head.

Mercuria: "Fire, I request your aid. Disperse the shadows and illuminate our bodies. Earth, I request your support. Preserve and stabilize our energy."

...

A peculiar, serene energy emanates from Mercuria. It gradually intensifies as its rhythm harmoniously synchronizes with the breath of everyone at the camp.

She chants in a low tone while the sage quietly burns.

Mercuria: "Fear not its arrival nor its influence, for it merely exists."

Phoebe returns, her hair still wet, while Cooper and Maich reconstruct the woodpile.

One by one, they reconvene in the plaza, collectively enveloped by Mercuria's aura of tranquility.

Mercuria: "It shall dissipate, taking away your burdens and impurities. From now on, your mind shall be clear, your feet shall be free, and none shall haunt you by any means."

...

The attendees fall into a hushed silence as their collective focus falls on Mercuria.

At this moment, the plaza is as placid as a lake under the glow of moonlight, where the smallest breeze could cause its surface to quiver.

Mercuria: Breathe in ... and out ...

Enveloped by the energy field they've created under Mercuria's direction, the crowd's woes start to dissipate.

Mercuria: Breathe in ...

Time seems to slow down with each passing breath. There is nothing but the gentle sound of distant cars and the occasional chirping of insects.

Mercuria: And out ...

The bundle of white sage has almost burned out, marking the end of the ceremony.

Mercuria: "Do not wander any longer. Feel your feet firmly on the ground. Descend, awaken, and swiftly return to the shore."

Mercuria: ...

Mercuria: ...

Mercuria: And that's it.

As the final remnants of the sage descend to the earth, the plaza transitions from tranquility to bustle.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Thank you, Mercuria.

Dexter covers his face in a gesture of piety. Behind him, the fire has been reignited.

Cooper the Healer: It's like the first time we had a bonfire gathering.

Edgardo the Masseur: Let's keep the party going, folks!

He picks up his guitar once more. Cooper and Maich scooch up beside each other to avoid the soaked end of the mat, and Phoebe finds a dry, sandy spot to sit down again.

Embarrassed by the need for everyone to adjust their seats, Dexter deliberately sits a little away.

Mercuria: You're welcome to come closer, Dexter.

Edgardo the Masseur: Yeah, c'mon! Have you forgotten, Dex? This shindig's for you, too!

Dexter gets up, shuffles closer to the fire, then drops back down.

Maich the Peddler: It's cool, Dex. You've been jinxed for so long that we're all used to it by now.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Yeah, you haven't sold any of my exorcism incense in like eight months. I'm getting used to that too.

A ripple of laughter spreads among the crowd.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Oh c'mon! Anyone would've thought they could make a fortune by selling incense at that time!

Edgardo the Masseur: Oh, yeah, times were tough for everyone. No one blames you, Dex.

Cooper the Healer: Eight months ... Poor Dexter, it seems like you're the only one still stuck in the muck.

Edgardo gently pats Dexter's shoulder. Dexter's expression sits somewhere between tears and laughter.

???: Emm ...

A hand slowly rises among the group.

Leah the Aromatherapist: What happened back then?

The group looks toward the voice. It belongs to someone they're not quite familiar with.

Leah the Aromatherapist: I wasn't here back then, so ... sorry ... can I ask?

Edgardo the Masseur: Of course you can, Little Leah.

Edgardo the Masseur: Newbies need to know where traditions come from so they can keep them alive.

Edgardo the Masseur: Now, listen to me.

The Stone-Picking Game

CH20603-02

Eight months ago.

Amidst the clamor of the marketplace, Mercuria appears to be searching for something.

She navigates through the crowd with a bundle of herbs in her hand.

Mercuria: Another one.

She spots a little ball of energy curled up in a corner and hurries over to it.

Mercuria: Gray, lifeless, moaning in pain.

She crouches down and presses her forehead against the small cluster of energy.

Mercuria: "Mother." It's saying, "mother."

With a flick of her fingers, Mercuria disperses the energy. It slowly reassembles.

Footsteps approach from behind her.

Soraya the Diviner: Huh? Aren't you the new girl at the market? What are you doing here?

Mercuria: Huh?

The woman's shadow casts over Mercuria's own. Mercuria turns and gazes upward, her eyes narrowed.

In the sunlight, her hair appears singed, dry, and rebellious.

Her facial features are distinctly Germanic, making her Romani attire seem almost like a costume.

Having gained Mercuria's attention, the woman turns her head to the side and shouts.

Soraya the Diviner: Yo, Bianca, get over here!

Bianca, the tarot reader, is sitting at a nearby open-air bar, savoring a glass of tequila.

Bianca the Tarotist: What?!

She responds with equal volume.

Soraya the Diviner: There's a girl here, or am I tripping again?

Bianca the Tarotist: Nope!

Bianca glances at Mercuria and brusquely spits out the slice of lemon she'd been chewing on.

Bianca the Tarotist: Just let her squat there and watch the ants, man!

Soraya the Diviner: Ugh, I'm not feeling well these days. I'm always dizzy, like someone's whispering in my ear and won't stop.

Bianca sets down her glass and walks over to Soraya, rubbing her palms.

Soraya the Diviner: Always pulling jokers when I'm playing cards, even though I swear I took them out, you know?

Bianca the Tarotist: Did you finish the meds Phoebe gave you?

Soraya the Diviner: You're always so over the top. You think Maich and Cooper got the same bug as me?

Soraya the Diviner: You felt any weird vibes lately?

Bianca the Tarotist: Well ...

Bianca pulls out a deck of tarot cards, shuffles them, and draws three.

Bianca the Tarotist: Wheel of Fortune, Four of Coins, Page of Coins.

Bianca the Tarotist: I keep pulling these cards lately. Is that weird or what?

Amidst their exchange, Mercuria quietly lights up the herb bundle in her hand.

Under the smoky haze, the ball of energy starts to fade away.

Mercuria scans her surroundings, ensuring the energy has completely vanished.

She swiftly locates some that have eluded capture.

Mercuria: Hem.

Mercuria extends her hand and lightly taps the hem of Soraya's skirt.

Soraya the Diviner: Whoops. Thanks. Must've picked up some dirt when I wasn't paying attention.

Bianca the Tarotist: Yeah, maybe your costume got caught on something. Ten bucks, and I'll lay out your spread.

Soraya the Diviner: This ain't just some "costume," it's my meal ticket—folks always trust a "gypsy" with their readings.

Soraya gently caresses her cuff, as if suddenly recalling something.

Soraya the Diviner: Besides, I can do my own readings, Bianca!

Amidst their dispute, Mercuria has already trotted away.

Bianca the Tarotist: ...

Soraya the Diviner: Hmm? Where's she going?

Mercuria makes her way to a faded hemp tent. The sounds of disorder emanate from within.

Customer II: What you tryna pull, man? I came for lotto numbers, not alphabet soup!

Dexter is attending to a visibly irate man. He seems resigned to absorbing the full brunt of his complaints.

Customer II: You hit me with six letters? Dexter? Break it down for me, will ya? Please?

Dexter the Unlucky One: Emm, ugh ... Well, it's like this ...

Dexter's left leg begins to quiver. He's nervously rubbing his hands together.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Um, each letter stands for a number, like A is one, B is two, you get it?

Customer II: And what about the other twenty-four numbers?

Dexter the Unlucky One: The other twenty-four?

The customer hits the table so hard that the basket on top of it goes flying into the air.

Dexter recoils, enduring this furious storm.

Customer II: Lottery numbers go from one to fifty, ya moron! I ain't payin' ya for this crap!

With a final slap of the table, he departs.

Upon the customer's exit, Mercuria approaches.

Mercuria: You can't seem to focus at all.

Mercuria's voice, though emotionless, is more pleasant than the customer's bellowing.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Hello, Ba ... Oh! Sorry, Ms. Barbara's next in line.

Mercuria: I'm just a drifter, not a customer. Name's Mercuria.

Mercuria: As for that lady, I asked her to wait outside for a moment.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Sorry, I've been super out of it lately. So, are you like our new neighbor or something?

Dexter rises unsteadily, pressing his hand to his forehead.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Let me get you some tea.

He heads over to a low camping table. Mercuria follows close behind.

On the table sits a capsized teapot, its tea pooling on the table's surface.

This is clearly a common occurrence, based on the plethora of other stains that have long since penetrated deep into the wood.

There is also a collection of fast-food boxes, a smattering of half-eaten snack bags, and a pile of flattened disposable cups.

Dexter has somehow managed to precariously balance them in a sort of crumpled tower.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Ah, sorry. My place isn't really set up for guests.

Dexter strokes his chin, abashed by the disheveled state of his tent.

But Mercuria's attention is directed elsewhere.

Mercuria: It's seeping out again.

Dexter the Unlucky One: What?

Mercuria squats behind Dexter, suffusing something with the herb bundle.

Mercuria: Your spirit, your energy ... Can't you feel it? It's spilling out of you. I can see it from that table to here.

Mercuria: The entire marketplace is imprinted with your essence. Everyone can feel it.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Sorry, can you not make it sound like I peed my pants or something?

Mercuria rises, a perplexed look in her eyes as she observes Dexter.

Mercuria: Your energy ... It's like a puddle in heavy rain. Chaotic and muddy, with leaves and insects tumbling around inside in panic.

Mercuria: You seek stillness, but find yourself adrift. You've lost your grounding, and it's causing your essence to overflow.

Mercuria: Mother Earth ... Yes, it mentioned "mother."

Mercuria: Are you looking for your mother?

Dexter's eyes widen in astonishment.

Dexter the Unlucky One: No ... I'm looking for her necklace. I lost it, and now she won't stop complaining.

Mercuria: It's not your mother. It's you.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Me?

Mercuria: You're putting too much pressure on yourself.

Mercuria: All your worrying about that necklace is causing your energy to leak right out. You haven't noticed it, but I've seen them—the formless children scattered around, all fixated on the necklace.

Mercuria gently touches the energy ball in her hand.

Mercuria: With every foot and fingerprint, you've left them behind. They're like children who have lost their mother, crying for attention.

Mercuria brings her hands together and up to Dexter's ear.

Mercuria: Now, the whole market can hear their cries.

Dexter shivers. It seems he heard something.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh!

Dexter, bewildered yet gracious, softly pushes Mercuria's hands away.

Dexter the Unlucky One: You hit on something, but it's still pretty hard to believe.

Dexter the Unlucky One: This is my arcane skill, not some energy leak.

Dexter stretches out a finger. A glowing ball forms at its tip, quickly transforming into a little figure.

It clings to Dexter's fingertip, looking sad.

Mercuria: They have the same expression.

Mercuria wiggles her finger at the figure. It scurries away onto Dexter's palm.

Mercuria: Oh, I didn't mean to scare you.

Mercuria apologizes to the little figure.

Dexter the Unlucky One: It's kinda unbelievable, don't you think? A stranger shows up and tells you that you're the reason the whole market's haunted.

Dexter the Unlucky One: What's your angle? Why are you coming to me like this? You want me to pay for damages?

Mercuria: No, I'm here to invite you to a healing ritual.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Aha.

He's caught on to her now.

Dexter the Unlucky One: So that's your scheme, huh? Talk crazy about people, get them confused, then hit them with the old "I've got the solution!"

Dexter the Unlucky One: Ha! You almost had me fooled!

Mercuria doesn't argue.

She just looks into Dexter's eyes, as calm as ever.

Mercuria: Listen to your heart.

She lifts her hand, placing her palm on Dexter's cheek.

Mercuria: It won't deceive you.

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...?

???: Hey, hey, Dexter!

???: Hey!

Dexter the Unlucky One: Whoa! Whoa! Mercuria?

Barbara: That girl from earlier? She left a while ago. How come you're sleeping so soundly?

Dexter the Unlucky One: Sorry, I just suddenly felt like I was flying or something. All light and comfy, just ...

Barbara: Got it. Same old.

Barbara pulls a keychain from the basket on the table and thrusts it into Dexter's hand.

Barbara: Could you hurry, please?

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...

Dexter, peering at the keychain in his palm, seems to awaken to the peculiar nature of this exchange.

Dexter the Unlucky One: May I ask you a question, Ms. Barbara?

Dexter the Unlucky One: Why do you keep buying the keychains I've touched? They're just giveaways.

Barbara: What?

Barbara: This isn't part of your curse service?

Barbara: "Please take this special gift. I think you'll like it."

Barbara: Did I misunderstand?

By the Moonlit Sea

CH20603-03

Maich the Peddler: I still think you're laying it on a little thick.

Maich pats Dexter's back, signaling him to search faster.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Can't whatever you have to say wait till I've dug it up, Maich?

Dexter is half-plunged inside Maich's crate as he searches its contents.

Dexter the Unlucky One: How do you ever find anything in this big thing?

Dexter stands up, his face black as if he'd just stuck it up a chimney.

Maich the Peddler: Whoa! You must've spilled my nightfall powder. I'll charge you for that!

Maich casually reaches into the crate and pulls out a brand-new Ouija board.

Maich the Peddler: How many have you broken this week? At this point, you should just get them wholesale. I can cut you a deal, you know.

Dexter the Unlucky One: What were we just talking about?

Maich the Peddler: That girl, Mercuria.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh yeah. I mean, come on. A stranger sees you for the first time and says, "You're flowing all over the market."

Dexter the Unlucky One: Why should I believe her? And why are you taking her side? I thought we were buddies!

Maich the Peddler: But you felt a bit better when she touched your face, didn't you?

Dexter hesitates, eventually giving a reluctant nod.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Alright, I admit, I did feel better.

Maich the Peddler: Why not try her healing ritual?

Across from the tent, Mercuria stands quietly by her sign.

"Purification Ritual—Banish the darkness, soothe the soul, and welcome the light of calm within."

Dexter the Unlucky One: She plays a good game with her ads. Makes more sense than her usual chatter, anyway.

Maich the Peddler: Oh, she's savvy for sure—knows how to fend for herself.

Maich the Peddler: But maybe not in a business sense. She's offering these rituals for free.

Dexter glances at Maich, who is still looking over at Mercuria.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Did you guys go to one of her rituals? How was it?

Maich the Peddler: Oh, that was good.

A look of satisfaction spreads across Maich's face as she recalls the ritual.

Maich the Peddler: The whispers in my ears are gone now, and the shadows in the corners of my eyes too.

Maich the Peddler: You gotta try it, Dex, believe me.

Dexter gives a noncommittal shake of his head.

Maich the Peddler: Listen, Dex, I really don't think that the strange stuff going on at the market is Mercuria's doing.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh, you're talking about me suspecting her of setting me up?

Maich the Peddler: Yeah.

Maich the Peddler: I'm pretty sure you already know that she's not doing anything that'll cause any harm, right?

Dexter fiddles with the Ouija board in his hands. He flips it over several times.

Dexter the Unlucky One: What if it really was me who made everyone uncomfortable?

Maich the Peddler: Hmm, maybe you'll feel better after Mercuria's purification ritual. Then you won't be, um, flowing everywhere, or whatever.

Dexter looks like he has more to say, but he bites it back.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh, alright.

Dexter the Unlucky One: I'll check it out, then. Just hope she doesn't purify me out of existence.

Maich the Peddler: What are you so worried about? You can handle yourself!

She gives Dexter a reassuring pat on the shoulder.

Dexter the Unlucky One: By the way ...

Dexter the Unlucky One: You got enough exorcism incense burning there? I can hardly see your face.

Maich the Peddler: Oh! Phoebe gave this to me. Didn't cost a dime, so it's no biggie.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Alright, alright.

Dexter shrugs, leaves some cash, and takes off.

Evening has arrived, signaling the commencement of the ritual. A crowd congregates in the plaza.

Their collective focus is captured by the newly ignited bonfire.

Ritual Participant I: She's here.

This phrase ripples from the front of the crowd to the back as everyone prepares their tools for the ritual.

Everyone but Dexter. He hangs back at the edge of the group.

Mercuria: Welcome to the healing ritual.

Mercuria: Now, grab your white sage or crystal, and let's get started.

Everyone raises their implements, ready for the ritual.

Ritual Participant II: Forgot to bring some? Here, share mine.

Having noticed Dexter's vacant expression, the participant graciously gives him half of their sage.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh, no one told me to bring any. Thanks.

Ritual Participant II: Don't mention it. It's free, just over there.

Dexter looks in the pointed-out direction and sees a small stall.

Beside it, the sign reads "White Sage, White Crystals."

Dexter the Unlucky One: Was that sign there the whole time?

Ritual Participant II: Uhh, I think so.

Mercuria: You can't seem to focus at all.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Man! Why's that popping into your head right now?!

Dexter's agitation mounts.

Ritual Participant II: Hmm? What was that?

The participant turns back to face him.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh, nothing.

Ritual Participant II: My bad. Thought I heard something.

The participant turns away, edging a little further from Dexter.

Mercuria: Now, if you have white sage, light it. If you have a white crystal, hold it up to the moonlight.

Mercuria's voice drifts from the front, quiet but audible.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Hey, got a light?

Dexter taps the participant beside him.

Ritual Participant IV: Nah, I got the crystal. Check with the dude on your right.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Sorry, my bad. I thought you were the one who gave me the white sage.

They've already moved on, focused solely on the crystal in their hand.

Mercuria: You can't seem to focus at all.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Ugh, forget her, man. She's got you totally mixed up.

Ritual Participant V: Get your foot off me!

Ritual Participant III: Oops, sorry. I thought you were trying to push to the front.

Ritual Participant V: I've been standing right here the whole time. I haven't moved an inch!

There is a faint sense of unease around Dexter.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Huh?

As his heart starts to thump harder, the unease around him grows into a ruckus. It's spreading from where he's standing.

Ritual Participant IV: Huh? Me?

Ritual Participant III: Leave me alone, okay?!

Ritual Participant II: Hey guys, what's happening?

Ritual Participant III: Oh!

The crowd recoils from the scream, leaving the participant in their own little circle.

Having noticed the disturbance, Mercuria approaches.

The kindled bundle of herbs leaves a trail of smoke as she walks.

Mercuria: It's shattered, but it's still a fine piece of crystal.

Mercuria picks up the fallen pendulum from the ground and returns it to the participant.

Dexter's legs go weak.

Dexter the Unlucky One: She knows the truth. She knows I'm the one to blame!

Ritual Participant II?: Yeah, that's him! I shouldn't have shared the herbs with him.

Ritual Participant III?: You brought bad luck to the entire market, and you're still bringing it now!

Dexter backs away, trying to blend into the crowd.

But Mercuria spots him instantly.

Dexter the Unlucky One: No.

He backs away.

Maich the Peddler?: This guy? He gave me a hard time. Even the inside of my lungs smell like incense now.

Cooper the Healer?: I have to redo my eyeliner every morning because of him!

Mercuria: Please calm down, Dexter.

She comes closer, still holding the burning sage.

Dexter can almost see the energy dissipating under her feet.

Maybe he'll be the next to vanish.

Dexter the Unlucky One: It wasn't me.

Mercuria: This won't hurt you, Dexter.

The crowd has already cleared the area of scattered spiritual energy around Dexter. He slips and falls to the ground.

Dexter the Unlucky One: No!

Dexter curls up, as if it would allow him to burrow underground, to a place where Mercuria can't find him.

But a cold hand brings his world back to quiet stillness.

Mercuria: You're okay, Dexter.

Mercuria raises her voice as she moves to guide the ritual participants.

Mercuria: Please calm down.

Mercuria: Breathe in ... and out ...

Mercuria: Breathe in ... and out ...

Mercuria: Now, feel my energy.

Mercuria: Your excess of emotion is tormenting you. You're worn down, Dexter.

Like a ruler drawn over uneven sand or a straw sweeping away the foam above the rim of a cup.

Dexter fits snugly into the container that is himself.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh ...

Dexter's breathing gradually regulates, like a crumpled piece of paper opened and pressed flat.

Mercuria smooths out every crease. Soon, Dexter is so relaxed that he can barely open his eyes.

Mercuria: You're alright now, Dexter.

Those were the last words Dexter heard that night.

The Day of Departure

CH20603-04

Present day.

Leah the Aromatherapist: Oh!

The little aromatherapist perches on her toes, leaning over the sandy ground next to the bonfire.

Leah the Aromatherapist: So that's what this bonfire gathering's all about—a big-time cleansing ritual.

Cooper the Healer: Before I joined this ritual, I'd never done a group meditation with this many people.

Cooper the Healer: I always feel like we're more connected afterward.

Cooper takes Maich's hand to her left and Leah's to her right.

Maich the Peddler: After about seven or eight rituals, we'd all pretty much been purified, so not many people come looking for Mercuria anymore. There's just us, really—and a few meditation enthusiasts.

Maich the Peddler: It's kinda turned into our own little private thing.

Cooper the Healer: We groove to Edgar's guitar, try Phoebe's latest mixes, and sometimes try to help Dex figure things out.

Cooper the Healer: Like hooking him up with purifying tools.

Leah the Aromatherapist: What have they given you?

Dexter the Unlucky One: These.

Dexter rolls up his left sleeve, revealing a number of jingling bracelets.

Maich the Peddler: Oh! There's the energy-cleansing bracelet I gave you!

Edgardo the Masseur: And my wooden beads.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Hmm—let me think, let me think.

Suddenly, she gets an idea.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Oh! Horseshoes!

Dexter parts his coat to reveal a belt adorned with not only horseshoe trinkets but also several rabbit's feet.

Maich the Peddler: Lucky cards!

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh ...

Dexter lets his coat fall back into place.

Maich the Peddler: Where's the lucky card Soraya gave you? If you've lost it, there's no getting a new one. She's long gone.

Dexter the Unlucky One: I just didn't bring it with me. I keep it under my pillow, so I don't lose it.

Maich nods in agreement.

Leah the Aromatherapist: I might have something I can give you too.

She grabs a scented candle and sets it down next to Dexter.

Leah the Aromatherapist: This'll help you sleep.

Cooper the Healer: That's all we can do to help, Dexter. Poor thing. I wish there were something else we could do.

A hush descends as everyone contemplates how else to help him. Maich quickly devises a solution.

Maich the Peddler: Well, we are missing someone from the market crowd—someone who's never even spoken with Dexter.

Cooper the Healer: Who's that?

Maich the Peddler: Bianca!

The group exchanges glances.

Cooper the Healer: Are we really gonna ask her?

Maich the Peddler: Bianca's never been to one of our bonfire gatherings, has she? Maybe she'll come up with something useful.

Phoebe the Herbalist: But I haven't seen her talk to anyone since Soraya took off.

Phoebe the Herbalist: Plus, her dad just showed up again.

Leah the Aromatherapist: Oh ...

Leah claps a hand over her mouth.

Leah the Aromatherapist: You mean that guy who was banging on her trailer's gas tank, hollering for booze money?

Phoebe the Herbalist: That's him. She's probably ducked to avoid the hassle. She tends to vanish for a couple of days whenever he shows up.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Let's not bother Bianca, then.

Dexter shifts uncomfortably.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Ah! Why's there mud here?

He despairingly smears the clump of mud from his hand onto his clothes.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Maybe if Mercuria purifies me a few more times, I'll get better!

The group's focus turns to the long-silent Mercuria. She's basking in the moonlight, cradling a crystal in her hands.

Mercuria: All I can do is pull the weeds. But, Dexter, your heart's already too tangled up.

Mercuria: Pretty soon, I won't be able to clear them as fast as they grow, and then nothing will work.

Dexter the Unlucky One: What should I do?

He starts to panic again. Even the others start to feel uneasy.

Mercuria instinctively waves away the spiritual energy spilling from Dexter's anxiety and lights another bundle of herbs.

Mercuria: I'll retrieve your mother's necklace. Will you come with me?

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...

Dexter lowers his head, inhaling the smoke from the sage.

Dexter the Unlucky One: *cough*

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...

Dexter the Unlucky One: It's been lost for nearly ten months now. No one knows where it is, Mercuria.

Mercuria: I know.

Dexter the Unlucky One: If I go with you ...

Edgardo the Masseur: Dex.

Edgardo, not usually one to butt in, cuts Dexter off.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Huh?

Maich the Peddler: You're in no shape to leave the market.

Maich the Peddler: Even if Mercuria's not here, you've still got us, and there are plenty of herbs and crystals to keep you steady.

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...

Cooper the Healer: If you leave the market, you'll scatter your energy everywhere. Mercuria can't handle all that on her own.

Dexter looks up at Mercuria, but she doesn't react. She's waiting for him to decide.

Dexter the Unlucky One: ...

The sage is burning unusually fast. Perhaps because there's an unusually large amount of energy to cleanse.

Mercuria: Have you made your decision?

Dexter stands still, running his fingertips over the grooves on the crate.

Dexter the Unlucky One: I think I'd better stay.

Mercuria: I see.

Mercuria: I'll leave you some purifying circles and tools. Do your best to keep a peaceful heart while I'm gone.

Mercuria: I'll set off first thing in the morning.

Maich the Peddler: But ...

Maich the Peddler: How're you gonna find it? We have no idea where he lost it in the first place.

Everyone nods in agreement. Maich has voiced the question on everyone's mind.

Mercuria closes her eyes. Slowly, her right hand rises, and her finger points. Her forehead gradually tilts in the same direction.

Mercuria: If you let it go, you'll find it one day.

Cooper the Healer: When will you come back?

Mercuria opens her eyes and looks at her companions by the fire.

Mercuria: We'll meet again.

Dawn. Mercuria sits on the ground.

Her stall is as empty as it was when she first arrived.

Mercuria has distributed her belongings among the members of the market, except for the worn map of America that she now holds in her hands.

Mercuria: Well ...

Her fingers glide across the map as she feels the energy beneath them. It's like she's searching for veins.

Like the path created by the fallen leaves of a tree or the echo of a cheerful little tune.

The bow slides joyfully against the strings. Whether in four or eight beats, its sound is sustained.

Then, it lands ever so softly, without stirring a single speck of dust.

Mercuria: Fresno.

Her fingertips land precisely on the name.

Mercuria: Huh?

Mercuria looks over at Bianca's trailer. It's been parked there for ages.

The yellow paint has long since flaked off, and the remaining patches have been obscured by dust.

It no longer serves as a vehicle, but its structure is intact enough to shelter Bianca from the elements.

After watching for a moment, Mercuria stands up.

She pats off the dirt on her backside, folds up the map, and begins her journey.

Vacation in California

CH20603-05

Street, Sausalito

Just outside the bike rental shop, Mercuria stands by the roadside, watching the traffic.

A thin sheen of sweat covers her face. Her fingers tap a gentle rhythm on her thigh.

She is listening intently, focusing on the faint voice of the necklace amidst the symphony of the world.

Mercuria: Four steps back.

She watches the passing cars as she murmurs to herself.

Mercuria: Too bright.

A car passes by.

Mercuria: A bit much.

She turns her attention to the next vehicle.

Mercuria: Sounds like jazz, but not the kind I'm looking for.

She shakes her head as the light turns green, and she crosses the street.

Mercuria: Northeast, like it's floating on a wave.

Mercuria reaches out to feel the flow of energy, her steps quickening.

Mercuria: Hurry. Follow me.

On these bustling streets, everyone knows their path.

Mercuria: Hurry. Follow me.

But Mercuria simply waits to embrace whatever comes her way.

Suddenly, she stops.

Mercuria: Hitchhiking ...

She seems to have suddenly understood something. She hails a white sedan.

This is a crescendo. It clarifies the necklace's energy.

Now's the time for the first movement to meet the second.

Mercuria: Could you give us a ride? I can't pay.

Mercuria leans into the open car window, the tassels on her clothes catching the sunlight.

Driver I: Where you headed?

Mercuria: Fresno.

Driver I: Hop in, lucky girls. I'll take you to San Lucas.

Mercuria: Thank you.

But Mercuria doesn't hop in. She turns back, searching for something.

Mercuria: Bianca, come on, this is your only chance!

Mercuria calls out into the crowd.

A woman wrapped in a headscarf reluctantly emerges from behind a bus stop sign and enters the sedan.

The car's interior is much livelier—or rather, chaotic—than Bianca anticipated.

Three brown hens and two white roosters strut around in the back, occasionally taking flight and landing on Bianca and Mercuria's heads.

A white bulldog with a swollen head lies leisurely at the passenger window, enjoying the breeze.

After the white rooster's third aerial show, Bianca can contain her irritation no longer.

Bianca the Tarotist: Why aren't they in cages?

Driver I: Well, so they produce the finest eggs in the county.

Bianca the Tarotist: You mean your county judges eggs on whether the chickens can fasten a seatbelt?

Driver I: Hahaha! Of course not. It's just to keep them in a good mood.

Driver I: Feel free to hold him, Ms. Bianca. Alexander's a very obedient chicken.

Bianca the Tarotist: He even has a name ...

Bianca wails as Alexander lands on her head for the fourth time.

Mercuria gently picks him up and places him on Bianca's lap.

Alexander promptly settles down.

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh! That's pretty sweet. I forgot about your calming touch.

Mercuria: It had nothing to do with me. He likes you.

Driver I: Good for you, Bianca!

Bianca gives an awkward response, and the car quickly falls quiet.

Bianca the Tarotist: Umm ...

Bianca the Tarotist: Emm ...

Bianca decides to voice the question that's been lingering in her mind.

Bianca the Tarotist: How long did you know I was here?

Mercuria: Since last night. I saw you sitting on the roof of a car.

Bianca the Tarotist: That long, huh?

Mercuria: I sensed your energy.

Bianca the Tarotist: So, you rented a bike and rode all the way from San Francisco to Sausalito just to mess with me?

Mercuria: No, I was following the necklace's energy.

Bianca the Tarotist: The necklace's energy?

Mercuria nods.

Bianca the Tarotist: So, was it the necklace's energy that told you that the best way to get from San Francisco to Fresno was to ride a bike from San Francisco to Sausalito, then catch a ride from Sausalito to San Lucas?

Driver I: What'll you do once you get to San Lucas?

Mercuria: You'll see when we get there.

Driver I: Oh ...

Driver I: What about D.C.? Got any plans to go there?

Bianca the Tarotist: D.C.?

Bianca takes Mercuria's map and eventually finds Washington, D.C. on the other side of the continent.

Bianca the Tarotist: No, no, we can't go there.

She quickly rejects the idea.

Bianca the Tarotist: So, Mercuria, when we get to San Lucas, let's take a bus to Fresno. I'll buy the tickets, okay? It won't take more than a few hours.

Mercuria: Why?

Bianca the Tarotist: Why? Because it's better than wandering aimlessly.

Mercuria: What's your final destination?

Bianca the Tarotist: Fresno.

Mercuria: That's where I'm going.

Bianca the Tarotist: ...

Bianca hesitates before rubbing her hair in frustration.

Bianca the Tarotist: Whatever. Have it your way.

Mercuria: Bianca.

Mercuria leans forward to come face-to-face with Bianca.

Mercuria: You've yearned for a journey like this, haven't you? Otherwise, you wouldn't have followed me.

Mercuria's eyes show no emotion. They're like shiny glass beads reflecting Bianca back on herself.

Bianca the Tarotist: You read me like a book, as always.

Bianca waves her hand in resignation.

Bianca the Tarotist: Alright, alright, I'll give it a shot.

Bianca the Tarotist: I know this girl who lives as free as the wind.

Bianca the Tarotist: She lands wherever she pleases and can take off at any time.

Maich the Peddler: But we're missing someone—someone who's never spoken with Dexter.

Cooper the Healer: Who's that?

Maich the Peddler: Bianca!

The hand poised to pry open a bottle cap pauses, seemingly surprised at her name being mentioned.

Then she goes ahead and opens it.

Bianca the Tarotist: It's a gathering I'd never join. I'm content watching from afar, just like at the beginning.

Bianca casually flicks the cap into a nearby trash bucket.

Leah the Aromatherapist: You mean that guy who was banging on her trailer's gas tank, hollering for booze money?

Bianca the Tarotist: Yep, that's my dad.

Bianca takes a swig, still unsure of where to hide from him tomorrow.

If her father finds her, it'll be yet another round of begging and stealing.

Bianca the Tarotist: I should've just split with Soraya and saved myself the headache.

But why didn't I bail when I had the chance?

Mercuria: I'll set off first thing in the morning.

Bianca the Tarotist: Huh?

Bianca murmurs to herself.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'll set off first thing in the morning.

Bianca the Tarotist: Why does she get to be so free?

Bianca rests her chin on her hand. She watches as they finish chatting, extinguish the bonfire, and disperse.

The New Age Market falls silent.

Bianca the Tarotist: Could I also live a free life like she does?

Suburbs, San Lucas

Bianca the Tarotist: ...

Mercuria: You're looking pretty down. Your energy's all wilted.

Bianca the Tarotist: An hour's walk on a rocky trail would wilt anyone. Don't you ever get tired?

But Mercuria's steps remain sprightly.

Bianca the Tarotist: Where are we?

Mercuria pulls out the map but hesitates to pinpoint their location.

Bianca the Tarotist: Mercuria?

Mercuria: I don't know. I'm following you.

Bianca stops and looks around.

The road winds upward through the mountains and disappears into the distance.

Bianca the Tarotist: So what do we do now? Go back the way we came and catch a ride in town, or keep going?

Mercuria: Hmm. It's up to you.

Street, San Lucas

50 minutes ago.

Having arrived in San Lucas, Mercuria and Bianca exit the sedan, brushing feathers off their clothes.

Bianca the Tarotist: That guy gave me an egg.

Bianca holds the egg up against the sun to see if there's an embryo inside.

Bianca the Tarotist: What's our next move?

Mercuria: Where do you feel like going?

Bianca the Tarotist: Let's find a spot to check if this egg's got any life in it first.

Mercuria: That shop will work.

Mercuria points nonchalantly at a building with a rooster on the roof.

Bianca the Tarotist: No, I decide where we go.

Bianca, eager to fulfill the promise she made in the car, is ready to take the lead.

She closes her eyes and spins around, stopping just before she falls.

Bianca the Tarotist: That way!

She points to a dirt road.

Bianca cradles the egg in her palm once again as she declares her decision.

Bianca the Tarotist: We'll go that way, and the first shopkeeper we find will tell us what's up with the egg.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'm not good at this spur-of-the-moment stuff.

Bianca leans forward, placing her hands on her knees as she tries to stretch her legs.

Bianca the Tarotist: What would you do in this kind of situation?

Mercuria: Follow the energy.

Bianca the Tarotist: Energy this, energy that!

Bianca plunks herself down on the ground.

Bianca the Tarotist: Where's your energy taking you now?

Mercuria: It's following you.

Bianca the Tarotist: Great!

Bianca lies down by the roadside.

Mercuria: Good idea. A break will do some good.

Mercuria lies down next to Bianca and closes her eyes. Her silver hair blends into the grass.

A grasshopper lands on her nose. She gently rubs her nose, causing it to hop away again.

Bianca the Tarotist: You gonna sleep just like that?

Bianca's nose is filled with the smell of fresh grass.

Mercuria: Ready to go?

Bianca the Tarotist: No.

Mercuria: Then why not sleep?

Mercuria turns her body away from Bianca as she prepares to take a nap.

Bianca doesn't know what choice to make.

So she just closes her eyes ever so tightly.

Mercuria: Bianca.

Bianca the Tarotist: Huh?

Mercuria: What an anxious way to sleep.

Bianca the Tarotist: For crying out loud, you're not even facing me!

Bianca turns her back to Mercuria.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'm not sleeping. I'm thinking.

The two remain silent. After a while, Bianca struggles, as if trying to break free from something.

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh!

She sits up and pulls out her tarot cards, but after a moment, she puts them back.

Bianca the Tarotist: Is this really how we're gonna get to Fresno?

Mercuria: Yeah.

Bianca the Tarotist: You sure we're not lost?

Mercuria: We'll get there one way or another.

Bianca the Tarotist: Jeez.

This sentiment drives Bianca to the brink of frustration.

Seriously? How—or when—are we gonna get there, then? Huh?!

The vagueness of Mercuria's statement prompts too many questions.

Mercuria: You can also choose to go back. It doesn't mean you're not free.

Not free ...

Bianca the Tarotist: *sigh*

Bianca brushes the hair from her forehead.

Bianca the Tarotist: If it were up to you, would you keep going?

Mercuria opens her eyes to look at Bianca.

Mercuria: I wouldn't have chosen this path in the first place. It's your journey.

Mercuria: But if it were up to me, I'd keep going into the unknown until something compelled me to stop.

Bianca stares into the distance at the road disappearing into the mountain.

Bianca the Tarotist: What if there's nothing beyond the mountain?

Bianca points just past the furthest point of the path that she can see.

Bianca the Tarotist: If there's nothing there, we'll go back to town.

Mercuria: Alright.

Bianca pulls Mercuria to her feet, and together they return to the path.

After what feels like an eternity.

Bianca the Tarotist: Huff ... huff ...

Suburbs, San Lucas

Every step Bianca takes feels like wading through thick sludge.

She forces herself to keep walking, but she's hardly making any progress.

Bianca the Tarotist: Uh ...

Bianca raises her head, realizing how far she still is from the highest point of the road.

Mercuria, however, shows no signs of fatigue. She's already at the summit, looking out over the landscape.

Mercuria: Come on, Bianca.

Once she's close, Mercuria reaches out to Bianca and helps her up the final ledge.

Mercuria: Look.

At the foot of the hillside, by a dark road, sits a little red house.

Bianca the Tarotist: That's not just any house—look at the sign out front. Who'd have thought there'd be a shop out here?

Bianca the Tarotist: Can you see what that sign says?

Mercuria shakes her head.

Mercuria: But I guess we're about to find out whether you'll get a pet chicken or not.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'm hoping more for a place to rest our feet.

Bianca the Tarotist: Or else my feet will be bleeding all over the place.

Rest Stop Reveille

CH20603-06

Bianca the Tarotist: "TRADE FOR TRADE" ...

Bianca reads the sign as she walks into the yard. There's an "Open" sign hanging on the door.

Bianca the Tarotist: Anybody home?!

She shades the glass on the door with her hands in an attempt to see inside.

Shopkeeper: You didn't drive here?

The shopkeeper emerges from the backyard. Her apron is covered in soil. She must have been tending to her garden.

Shopkeeper: Come on in. The door's unlocked.

Bianca pulls the door open. Its bell rings.

Roadside Shop

The thrift shop is filled with a wide variety of goods, each with its own level of quality—likely a result of the bantering among its customers.

Bianca the Tarotist: Ceramic clocks, rain boots, fans, diving gear ...

Shopkeeper: Even urns for ashes.

The shopkeeper doffs her apron as she enters from the back door.

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh, right! Could you help me see if this egg will hatch a chick?

Bianca produces a small basket from her waist that she weaved from the threads of her hem during the long walk.

Shopkeeper: Let me see.

The shopkeeper retreats before returning with a small flashlight.

She shines it into the egg, revealing the unformed body within.

Shopkeeper: Oh, I see it. It's growing, that's for sure. Are you planning to keep carrying it around like this? Some kind of new-age prenatal education?

Bianca the Tarotist: I just picked it up on our way here.

Shopkeeper: Better put it somewhere warm and safe soon. It won't hatch if it doesn't get the care it needs.

Bianca carefully takes the egg from the shopkeeper and puts it back in the basket.

Bianca the Tarotist: Why'd you open a shop all the way out here? You get many visitors?

Shopkeeper: Oh, I get a few from time to time, and they always surprise me.

Bianca the Tarotist: Does this count as a surprise?

Bianca nods to the egg in the basket.

Shopkeeper: Oh, not at all, young ladies. I'm a godmother to many children.

Shopkeeper: There are more kids born on these roads than you'd think, and I just so happen to have some medical know-how.

Shopkeeper: As for why I opened the shop ...

The shopkeeper strikes an elegant pose, as if on camera.

Shopkeeper: When you begin a journey, no one knows exactly what will happen. Embracing the unknown can be a lot of fun.

She looks fondly at the items in the shop.

Shopkeeper: Each piece in this place holds a fragment of a traveler's life.

Shopkeeper: It's like I'm living in a different movie every day.

Bianca the Tarotist: What was the first thing you traded for?

Shopkeeper: That's a question I hear a lot.

She opens the cash register and pulls out a wad of bills.

Shopkeeper: When I exchanged a roll of toilet paper for this, I thought, "Hey, this is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity!"

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh, I thought it'd be something a little more heartwarming.

Shopkeeper: This is the real world, kid. But I'm not just about money—have a look around. I never ask for much.

She flicks on the overhead lights, and the place lights up.

Bianca the Tarotist: You're not worried about trading for stuff nobody wants? Like this microscope?

Shopkeeper: Oh, well, someone might need that to examine the leaves up in the mountains. Everything has its use, right?

Shopkeeper: They all find their way in the end. I don't stress about it.

Bianca scans the shelves. There are all kinds of oddities.

Mercuria: Bianca, I think this'll suit you.

Mercuria's voice rings from the shelf near the shop entrance.

Bianca the Tarotist: What?!

Mercuria: A dress.

Bianca follows the sound to find Mercuria holding a gown from the shelf.

It's a bold, vibrant red dress with a backless design that would make its wearer the center of attention at any party.

Mercuria: It's beautiful.

Bianca the Tarotist: Yes ... it's beautiful ...

Bianca takes the dress from Mercuria, draping it over her shoulder to see how it looks.

Bianca the Tarotist: But when would I wear it? I can't do tarot readings at the market in an evening gown.

Bianca the Tarotist: It's not really me.

Bianca examines herself in the mirror, picturing herself dancing in the gown at a disco.

Bianca the Tarotist: It's a bit too much.

With a hint of pity, Bianca hangs the dress back up.

Bianca the Tarotist: Let's look for something else.

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh!

Shopkeeper: You find something you like?

Bianca the Tarotist: Not yet. Wait, this is ...

Bianca picks up a necklace from the shelf. Its chain is rusted, and the photo inside the locket is speckled with black spots.

Bianca the Tarotist: This is the necklace Dexter's been looking for!

Mercuria glides over.

Bianca the Tarotist: How the ... what ... Is this what you expected, Mercuria?

Mercuria: This is the path you chose, Bianca. I've merely followed you.

Bianca the Tarotist: Oh my God, oh my God, oh my God! I've actually found Dexter's necklace that's been missing for ten months! How much is it?

Fully immersed in the joy of her discovery, Bianca quickly looks for the necklace's price tag.

Bianca the Tarotist: It's a free gift?

Shopkeeper: What did I say? Every item serves a purpose for someone in the world.

The shopkeeper smiles warmly, perhaps genuinely happy for Bianca's delight.

Bianca the Tarotist: So, does that mean we can just take it?

Shopkeeper: It means you have to buy something first.

The shopkeeper's joy turns into the satisfied smile of a farmer with a barn full of wheat.

Bianca the Tarotist: Okay, then let's pick out something else.

Bianca searches the shelves, looking for something that won't be too bothersome to take back with her.

Bianca the Tarotist: This ceramic clock? It's a bit heavy.

Bianca picks it up, weighs it, and puts it down again.

Her eyes keep landing on the red dress, but she continues to peruse the shop.

Bianca the Tarotist: Rain boots? Probably more comfortable than my heels. They can be kinda heavy, though.

The allure of the red dress persists, but she has virtually no occasion to wear it.

Bianca ducks her head below the shelf to avoid seeing it again.

Bianca the Tarotist: A fan? That'll cool us down for the rest of the trip—if it doesn't need electricity, that is ...

Mercuria: Bianca.

Bianca the Tarotist: Huh?

Bianca stares at Mercuria who has picked up the red dress once again.

She can practically hear the spell-binding pitch about to leave Mercuria's lips.

She needs to speak up before she's convinced—maintain some semblance of control.

Bianca the Tarotist: Fine, fine, I'll take it.

She gives in completely.

Shopkeeper: Just follow this road, and you'll get to Fresno pretty quick. You might even be able to hitch a ride.

Bianca the Tarotist: Thank you!

The shop door swings open, and out step Mercuria and Bianca, wearing the red dress.

Bianca the Tarotist: This dress, Dexter's necklace—it's all kinda nuts.

Bianca is still riding the double high of finding the necklace and getting the dress she wanted.

Mercuria: So, where are we headed now?

Bianca the Tarotist: Fresno.

Mercuria: Let's go.

Bianca the Tarotist: Let's.

Bianca strides forward, the movement of her dress revealing a pair of glossy black rain boots on her feet.

Go With the Flow

CH20603-07

Street, Fresno

Bianca the Tarotist: Thanks for the ride. See ya!

Bianca and Mercuria climb out of the car.

Driver II: Happy weekend, ladies!

Bianca the Tarotist: Phew! Fresno, we finally made it.

Bianca drifts along the sidewalk like a half-deflated balloon.

Bianca the Tarotist: Gotta walk on my toes. Think I'll scream if my heels touch the ground.

Mercuria: Look, there's a restaurant right here.

Bianca the Tarotist: Guess this is our best bet. My feet are killing me.

Leaning on Mercuria and wincing from the blisters, Bianca shuffles into the restaurant on her toes.

Skunk Salsa Restaurant

The place isn't busy, so they're seated right away, and a server comes over to take their order.

Bianca the Tarotist: Two beef tacos, some corn chips, and ... can I grab a fortune cookie?

Server: Of course.

The server places a fortune cookie on the table before heading to the kitchen.

Mercuria gets up to follow her.

Bianca the Tarotist: Huh?

Bianca stops cracking open her fortune cookie. She watches Mercuria talking to the manager in the kitchen through the pass-through.

They seem to have struck some kind of deal. Mercuria heads back.

As soon as she sits, Bianca hits her with a flurry of questions.

Bianca the Tarotist: You know each other?

Mercuria: Just met.

Bianca the Tarotist: What were you two chatting about?

Mercuria: A job.

Bianca the Tarotist: A job?

Bianca looks around, puzzled.

Bianca the Tarotist: I don't sense anything unusual here.

Mercuria: A job as a waitress.

Bianca the Tarotist: A waitress?

Mercuria: Yeah. You should always start by getting a job when you settle in a new city.

Bianca looks incredulously at Mercuria.

Bianca the Tarotist: You're not heading back? And you're not gonna keep doing the spiritual healing thing?

Mercuria: I'll stay here for a while, just like I did when I first arrived in San Francisco. Being a spiritual healer isn't all I do. I just need to settle down first.

Bianca the Tarotist: Ah ...

In her surprise, Bianca accidentally pops open the fortune cookie.

Bianca the Tarotist: You've already made up your mind?

Mercuria nods lightly.

Bianca the Tarotist: So, what about Dexter's necklace?

Mercuria: You can bring it back.

Mercuria's reply is serene.

Bianca the Tarotist: Was this your plan from the beginning?

Mercuria nods.

Mercuria: This is how I live.

Indeed, she's a free soul.

Bianca reads the message from the fortune cookie: "You will always have true friends by your side."

Bullsh*t.

Bianca crumples it into a ball.

Bianca the Tarotist: You did give away all your stuff before you left.

Bianca the Tarotist: I should've figured you wouldn't go back.

Mercuria: But you will.

Bianca wraps her fingers around the cookie, pressing it lightly into her palm.

True friends ... What's Soraya doing now, and in which city?

Bianca the Tarotist: Me? I don't think so.

Why can't I be as free as Mercuria?

Her grip tightens.

Mercuria: Is that so?

Why didn't I just leave back then?

'Cause I couldn't do it.

Bianca the Tarotist: Yeah.

"Bianca, sweetie, come on over to Daddy."

No matter how bad I want to leave ...

When it's time to really hit the road, I just can't seem to take that step.

But for Mercuria, it seems so easy.

Bianca the Tarotist: Yes. I'm sure.

"Crack!"

Mercuria: Bianca.

Mercuria grabs Bianca's hand. Her fortune cookie has been reduced to crumbs.

Bianca the Tarotist: No. Don't cast your arcane skill on me.

What was once calming now feels like a snake ready to strike.

Bianca pulls away from Mercuria's touch. She realizes her eyes are wet with tears.

Bianca the Tarotist: I never realized how awful it is to lead a calm, uneventful life.

Mercuria's hand remains extended, but Bianca can't discern her expression through her tears.

Now that her friend is gone, Bianca finally sees how lonely and trapped she is in San Francisco.

Bianca the Tarotist: Dad ...

She resents him. The man she once admired is the very same man who's now restraining her—holding her tight in his grip.

But that's not the only reason.

Bianca the Tarotist: Soraya ...

Mercuria: Yeah, eventually you'll go back.

Bianca has calmed down.

Mercuria sits opposite, watching her idly flick corn chips on the table as her emotions dissipate.

She unapologetically snatches Mercuria's taco after finishing her own.

Mercuria: You seem to be in a better mood.

Bianca nods.

Bianca the Tarotist: Thank you. This journey's been nice. I feel like I've just woken up from a day-long hangover.

Bianca the Tarotist: I found Dexter's necklace, got a dress I love, and had a real adventure.

Bianca the Tarotist: I ... I don't think I have the nerve to start over somewhere else, Mercuria. I'm not like you.

Mercuria: It's not about nerve, Bianca. It's just how I live.

Mercuria: I was born without a home.

Mercuria: Now, may I hold your hands?

Mercuria's hand is still outstretched. She extends the other. Bianca nods and places her hands in Mercuria's.

But Bianca doesn't feel that familiar warmth in her soul. Mercuria is simply holding her hands, not casting her arcane skill.

Mercuria: Thank you for showing me that granting inner peace doesn't always help.

Bianca smirks.

Bianca the Tarotist: Since this dream is coming to an end, shall we do something to complete it?

Mercuria: What do you propose?

Bianca the Tarotist: I've never seen myself dancing in a party dress.

Mercuria: Let's go.

The two girls wander through Fresno. They pause as music hits their ears.

Busker: ♪ Hopped on the express train. ♪

Busker: ♪ With little else but a ticket in hand. ♪

The busker's song floats through the bustling streets, leading Bianca and Mercuria to its source.

His lazy, raspy voice carries the miles he has traveled.

Busker: ♪ Hopped on the express train. ♪

Strumming his time-worn guitar, he lazily leans on a pile of cardboard and plastic bags.

His fingers are stained, but they still produce a wonderful sound.

Bianca kicks off her rain boots, grabs the hem of her skirt, and dances barefoot before the singer. A small crowd starts to gather.

Busker: ♪ Might follow you, might go my own way. ♪

Mercuria can't help but join the dancing.

This will be the most beautiful scene in Fresno tonight.

Two figures, one in red and one in silver, ignoring the world around them and dancing out their zest for life.

Busker: ♪ See you next time, see you next time. ♪

Bianca the Tarotist: ♪ See you next time, see you next time. ♪

Bianca sings wholeheartedly, not wanting the night to end, not wanting this free-spirited dream to fade.

Busker: ♪ Tomorrow's gotta be better than today. ♪

She believes it. Tomorrow will be better.

The Good Old Days

CH20603-08

Driver III: Hey, wake up.

Driver III: Hey!

Bianca the Tarotist: Huh?

Driver III: We're here.

Bianca the Tarotist: Thank you.

A night of wild dancing has left Bianca utterly exhausted.

It's five in the morning, and the dawn chorus has begun. Birds flit from branch to branch, chirping to one another.

But it is not yet time for the New Age Market to awaken.

Most stalls sit empty, while a few contain people in deep meditation as they quietly make the most of the morning.

Edgardo the Masseur: Ah. Can I help you with anything, Miss?

Edgardo's words are cut short.

Edgardo the Masseur: Bianca?

Edgardo looks at her up and down.

Edgardo the Masseur: That's a pretty dress. Did you just get it?

He hesitates before continuing.

Edgardo the Masseur: Bianca, some stuff went down at the market while you were gone.

He's choosing his words carefully.

Edgardo the Masseur: Mercuria, she ...

Bianca the Tarotist: She's gone, I know. I went with her.

Edgardo the Masseur: Oh!

It's hard to tell if he's more shocked that Bianca ran into Mercuria or that she was traveling with her.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'm beat, Edgardo. Gonna crash for a while.

Bianca the Tarotist: Could you get everyone together? I have something to say.

Edgardo the Masseur: Sure, leave it to me.

Bianca drags herself back to her trailer.

She falls into a deep sleep.

In her dream, there's no pain in her feet, no sad farewells, no trivial family matters.

Only peace. An indescribable peace, like a crystal lake nestled in the boundless mountains.

Bianca wakes up. Not wanting to leave the serenity of her dream, she lies in bed with her eyes closed, reliving it in her mind.

Edgardo the Masseur: Uh. Bianca. Are you awake? Bianca?

Outside the car window, a bonfire burns gently under the night's sky.

Edgardo the Masseur: We've almost got everyone.

Bianca the Tarotist: Alright.

Bianca the Tarotist: I'll come on out in a sec.

She pulls herself out of bed, bandages up her feet, and gives the egg a pat before heading out.

As soon as Bianca shows up, she's bombarded with questions.

Maich the Peddler: You went to Fresno with Mercuria?

Dexter the Unlucky One: How's she doing?

Phoebe the Herbalist: She still looking for that necklace?

Bianca the Tarotist: Shh!

Bianca takes the necklace out and passes it to Dexter.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Th-This is ...

Dexter opens the locket, touching the little photo he knows so well.

Dexter the Unlucky One: It's back! It's back!

He flings it around his neck.

Elsewhere, at this very moment.

Skunk Salsa Restaurant.

???: Now you've lost your employee ID card, too? Your luck's been awful lately. Here, I bought this lucky keychain for you at a market today. Maybe it'll help you find it.

Skunk Salsa Restaurant

Foundation Employee: But, you've already given me a bunch of these keychains.

He lifts his keychain. There are more decorations than actual keys on it.

Foundation Employee: I'm not sure this'll make any difference.

???: It'll work! Come on, let's go test it out!

Foundation Employee: Huh?

Without another word, she pulls the man out of the restaurant.

Mercuria: Cash or card?

But the two walk right past her. Mercuria watches them as they go.

Mercuria: Should I use the wallet they left here to settle the bill?

Mercuria walks to their table and wipes it down.

Mercuria: Huh?

She notices a wisp of gray-white energy at her fingertips.

Mercuria: Dexter?

But the man was clearly not Dexter. Mercuria looks at the item on the table.

Mercuria: Dexter's gift keychain.

She recalls when she first met Dexter.

There was a woman waiting anxiously outside the tent that night, right after that furious man left.

Mercuria: That was her. Barbara.

Mercuria peers out the restaurant window, watching the backs of the two who just left.

Barbara is hurriedly pulling the man to the other end of the street, but the man seems to remember something. He stops her, searches himself, and insists they return to the restaurant.

The energy at Mercuria's fingertips dissipates.

Mercuria: Looks like Dexter got his necklace.

Mercuria: Oh, the power's gone.

An out-of-control car rushes past where Barbara was moments before. It veers off the road and collides with a wall.

If it hadn't been for the man's return for his wallet, Barbara's fate would have been sealed.

Mercuria: Perfect timing.

Mercuria heads over to the phone and makes an emergency call.

Barbara sits paralyzed with fear on the ground. The man helps her up and walks her back to the restaurant.

Foundation Employee: Sorry.

The man enters with Barbara. She's shaking like a leaf.

Foundation Employee: Can I get a hot chocolate? She's scared stiff.

Barbara: *sob*

Barbara's eyes are wide. She stares firmly at her feet, horrified by what would have happened if she'd taken one more step.

Mercuria: Alright.

The man guides her back to her seat.

Sirens blare in the street. The blue and red lights of the police car illuminate the chaos of the figures outside.

Mercuria brings a cup of hot chocolate to Barbara.

Mercuria: Relax. You're safe now.

Mercuria gently strokes Barbara's head.

Under Mercuria's soothing touch, Barbara's breathing steadies, and her face loses its look of terror.

Foundation Employee: Oh! An arcanist with a healing skill!

Mercuria gives him a nod.

Foundation Employee: Ha! Did that car crash just burn through all my bad luck?

The man trembles as he picks up his wallet from the table, pulls out a business card, and hands it to Mercuria.

Foundation Employee: Have you heard of the St. Pavlov Foundation?

Foundation Employee: We're in need of an arcanist healer. You would be of great use to us.

Mercuria: ...

The group lingers on the story of Bianca and Mercuria's unexpected journey.

Maich the Peddler: So you'll have a chick soon?

Phoebe the Herbalist: Are you gonna use it for your tarot readings?

Cooper the Healer: Oh, a journey ...

Cooper is leaning back with her eyes closed. She seems to be lost in some kind of fantasy.

Dexter the Unlucky One: So, Mercuria's working as a waitress at a place called Skunk Salsa Restaurant?

Bianca the Tarotist: Yes.

Dexter stands up excitedly, touching the necklace around his neck.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Maybe, maybe I should go thank her in person!

Edgardo the Masseur: Go for it!

Maich the Peddler: Go on!

Everyone encourages him.

Edgardo the Masseur: You're not a walking jinx anymore now that you've got your necklace back! You'll bring no harm.

Cooper the Healer: Won't have to offer curse services anymore, either.

Maich the Peddler: You might want to think about changing your keychains, too. No one would want them even if you paid them.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Oh!

Dexter looks hurt.

Dexter the Unlucky One: Believe me, these were the pick of the bunch.

There's a gentle collective jeer, followed by a break into other conversation.

Edgardo the Masseur: So, Bianca ...?

He asks in a low voice.

Edgardo the Masseur: You gonna keep coming to these meetups?

Bianca the Tarotist: Of course. As soon as I solve my dad's problem.

Edgardo the Masseur: How do you plan to do that?

Bianca the Tarotist: I registered him for a support group for alcoholics. It's filled with people who've been through the same—unemployment, getting laid off, feeling aimless ...

Bianca the Tarotist: I think it'll be good for him.

Bianca the Tarotist: Hey. Edgardo.

Something occurs to her. She puts her hand on Edgardo's shoulder.

Bianca the Tarotist: We all know you're a good guy, and I don't mean any offense, but maybe ... Well, I was thinking ...

Bianca is trying to choose her words carefully.

Bianca the Tarotist: Maybe ... When they left, did Soraya tell you where they were going?

Edgardo the Masseur: Of course! I'll tell you all about it later.

He gives Bianca a pat on the shoulder before going back to his guitar.

Edgardo the Masseur: ♪"Oh-oh, who could say no to a night like this?"♪

I hope that every night from now on ...

Can be just like tonight.